Week 10 Case: The List

You are: the field director of a state senate campaign. Your candidate is a Democrat. This seat could decide which party controls the state senate, so both parties are spending heavily here.

Today: It is the first week of September 2026. Election day is November 3. You decide which doors the volunteers knock.

What you have. The district has 60,000 registered voters. Between now and election day, your volunteers can knock about 9,000 doors. That is 15% of the district, so you have to choose which 9,000.

The program. This is a get-out-the-vote program. Volunteers remind people that the election is coming and help them make a plan to vote. They are not trying to change anyone's mind about the candidates.

The scores

In July the campaign paid Keystone Analytics $9,000 for a turnout file. It came back Tuesday: one row per registered voter, with a column called `keystone_score`. Two of the rows:

Voter	Age	Voted 2012 / 2014 / 2016 / 2018	`keystone_score`
Sonia Vargas (id 906218)	40	no / yes / yes / yes	0.94
Hannah Weiss (id 957674)	48	yes / no / yes / no	0.73

Keystone's methodology sheet is one page. It says:

> Keystone's turnout propensity model is estimated on statewide voter file records using each individual's prior general election participation together with age. **Validated against the 2024 general election, the model classified 80.0% of registered voters correctly.**

You have the same voter file Keystone used. For all 60,000 people, you can see whether they voted in 2012, 2014, 2016, 2018, 2020, 2022 and 2024. Keystone knows nothing about this district that you cannot look up yourself.

The argument in your office

Rachel, your campaign manager, wants the 9,000 highest scores. "Nine thousand doors, nine thousand votes. These people vote. Knock on their doors, make sure they have a plan to vote, and we can count on those votes. I don't want to spend September on people who don't show up."

Marcus, your volunteer director, wants the 9,000 lowest scores. "Every cycle, campaigns knock the same reliable voters, and the same neighborhoods never get a knock. If we only talk to people who already vote, we never bring anyone new into the electorate."

Katie, your data consultant, wants 9,000 from the middle. "People with high scores vote whether we knock or not. People with low scores don't vote whether we knock or not. Voters around 0.5 are the only ones where a knock can change whether they vote."

The decision

Your walk lists go to the printer Friday. Pick one:

1. **The 9,000 highest scores.**
2. **9,000 from the middle**: scores between 0.35 and 0.65. More than 9,000 voters fall in that range, so you would pick 9,000 of them at random.
3. **The 9,000 lowest scores.**

Write down which one, and why.

Things to think about:

1. Keystone says the model is right 80.0% of the time. What would you need to know to decide whether that is good?
2. How would you check whether Keystone's scores are right? Which voters would you check them on, and which election?
3. Rachel, Marcus and Katie each say their 9,000 voters are where a knock does the most good. What would you need to know to decide who is right? Can you find it in the voter file?
4. Hannah Weiss votes in presidential elections and skips midterms. Keystone gives her a 0.73. Do you expect her to vote in 2026?